into the farm sector, and ensure wider market access to the farmers. But the unions could not be convinced.

The ministry now seems to be pinning its hopes on digitisation, for which Rs 968 crore has been earmarked, and strengthening of the cooperative and FPO (farmer producer organisation) networks across the country. But these, too, will take time to show results. For instance, the digital agri trading platforms, eNAMs, were launched in 2016, but even now only 1,260 of the 6,900 APMC *mandis* in India are connected.

Money, however, has been flowing to strengthen irrigation facilities, issuing of soil health cards and assured procurement of certain pulses and oilseeds. So far, 230 million soil health cards have been issued. The crop insurance scheme, PM Fasal Bima Yojana, has also been effective—claims worth Rs 1.3 lakh crore have been settled since 2016. Budget allocations have been increasing over the years, but a parliamentary committee in March noted that Tomar's ministry has surrendered Rs 44,016 crore in unspent funds in the past three years. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

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Corpus in Agriculture Infrastructure Fund for loans



BUT...

Only 1,260 of 6,900 APMC mandis in India connected to eNAM

Parshottam Rupala

Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

PRIZE CACHE

Challenges apart, the minister in charge has quite a lot to show for a ministry that is just four years old

By Himanshu Shekhar

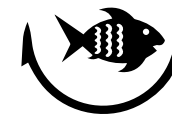
ONE OF THE BIGGEST challenges for Parshottam Rupala, who in 2021 took charge of a ministry that was formed just four years ago, came in the form of the lumpy skin disease, which felled thousands of cattle across the country last year. For the world's top milk-producing nation, it was a mega crisis. The ministry, however, managed to stem it swiftly. "We were holding regular meetings with the affected states. We had also set up a control room in the ministry, and vaccination was in full swing," says Rupala about the efforts.

On the fisheries front, the several schemes that the government has launched to boost the sector have resulted in fish production reaching an all-time high of 16.24 million tonnes in FY22; sea-food exports, too, saw record earnings of Rs 57,586 crore that year. The ministry is currently focusing on the Sagar Parikrama Yatra, which is intended to create awareness among fish farmers and coastal communities across India. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

16.2 MILLION TONNES

The record fish production in 2021-22



BUT...



Retail price of milk has risen 12% from a year ago